Additional lesson · *The Tempest*, Act 3 Scene 3: the Harpy

Grade 11 English Home Language · Literature: drama · Reading a dramatic climax as a staged scene

Grade and subject	Grade 11, English Home Language
Curriculum context	CAPS English Home Language, FET Phase: Literature (drama). Annual Teaching Plan Term 3, Week 8. Prescribed text: William Shakespeare, *The Tempest*.
Duration	45 minutes (one period)
Language skills	Reading and viewing; speaking and listening; writing (brief written responses during the Q&A)
Teaching strategies	Experiential learning, visualisation, guided practice, differentiated instruction, peer reading
Cross-curricular link	Visual Art and drama: physical staging, prop work and sound design used to interpret a literary text, showing how theatrical spectacle and sensory overload convey narrative climax and psychological pressure
Taught	Abbotts College Pretoria East, 4 September 2026, five Grade 11 classes

Learning outcomes

By the end of the lesson, learners will be able to read and analyse Act 3, Scene 3 of *The Tempest*, focusing on the climax of the nobles' plot and Ariel's Harpy speech. This connects to the real world by exploring how guilt, psychological pressure and sensory manipulation can be used to break down authority figures and force them to confront their past actions.

- **Skills:** close reading of a dramatic climax, analysing physical staging cues, and interpreting psychological warfare.
- **Knowledge:** comprehension of the illusory banquet, the shifting power dynamics among the nobles, and Ariel's judgement of the "three men of sin".
- **Values and attitudes:** understanding the psychological weight of guilt and recognising the consequences of betrayal.

Theme and key concepts

The illusory banquet. This contextualises the psychological breakdown of the nobles when faced with their past sins, highlighting how Prospero uses psychological warfare rather than direct physical violence to conquer his enemies.

- **Climax:** the point of highest tension or turning point in a narrative, represented here by Ariel confronting the guilty nobles.
- **Theatrical spectacle:** the use of grand visual and auditory illusions (the magically appearing and disappearing banquet, the Harpy) to overwhelm the characters' senses.
- **Psychological warfare:** tactics used to manipulate an enemy's psychological state and induce exhaustion, guilt and madness, effectively breaking their will to fight.

Learning and teaching support materials

- Whiteboard and markers; desks arranged as a banquet table; fizzy sweets as props
- Smartphone or laptop with external speakers for dramatic music and thunderstorm sound effects
- Prescribed text: *The Tempest*

Technology in the lesson. A smartphone and external speakers play dramatic music and thunderstorm audio effects during Ariel's Harpy speech. This elevates the tension of the scene and creates an immersive, theatrical and playful atmosphere.

Lesson sequence

Stage	Time	What happens
Hook	5 min	Before the learners arrive, I draw little black wings on the whiteboard and physically rearrange the classroom: a group of desks becomes a central banquet table for the nobles, the remaining desks form a semi-circle around it, and fizzy sweets on the central table stand in for the magical banquet.
Introduction	5 min	I assign the reading roles and position the learners physically in the space: the noble characters at the central banquet table, the rest of the class in the semi-circle as the surrounding spirits, and the learner reading Ariel front and centre. I set the context for the scene: Prospero's trap for the elites is finally closing after they have been wandering the island in exhaustion, growing hopelessness and plotting.
Body	25 min	We read the scene aloud. I pause to analyse the nobles' physical exhaustion and Alonso's despair over his missing son. At the climax I trigger the dramatic music and thunderstorm effects while Ariel delivers the Harpy speech condemning the "three men of sin". We break down the mechanics of the scene, analysing how Prospero uses the disappearing banquet and Ariel's accusations as psychological warfare to drive his enemies to madness.
Consolidation	5 min	I wrap up by highlighting how this sensory overload breaks the nobles' sanity, leaving them completely at Prospero's mercy. This immersive reading sets up the following lesson, in which we watch the Royal Shakespeare Company perform the same scene.
Reserve	5 min	Learner questions and a quick check of the three key concepts before the bell.

Learner participation

Learners actively read their assigned roles from their staged positions in the classroom, hand out the fizzy-sweet props during the banquet sequence, and take part in the informal question-and-answer discussion of Ariel's speech and the nobles' reactions. Every learner has a role, either as a named character at the table or as one of the island's spirits in the semi-circle.

Differentiation

Reading roles are allocated so that confident readers take the long speeches and reluctant readers take shorter parts or act as the surrounding spirits, so everyone is part of the scene. The staging, props and sound carry the meaning for learners who find the Early Modern English hard, while the pause-point questions push stronger learners to analyse how the spectacle works as psychological warfare.

Assessment opportunities

Informal, formative. Learners take part in the staging of the scene and answer questions about it. I assess this through an informal Q&A during the pauses in the reading, checking comprehension by tracing how well they understand the psychological trap Prospero has set. Misunderstandings are corrected on the spot and inform the following revision lesson.

Reflection after teaching

Arranging the desks and using fizzy sweets as props immediately engaged the learners; corny as it was, it was fun, and it made the complex staging of the scene tangible. Playing the dramatic music and thunderstorm effects during Ariel's speech was a little melodramatic, but the learners got completely into it and it underscored the moment as the emotional climax of the text. The informal Q&A showed they clearly grasped the psychological weight of Ariel's accusations against Alonso, Antonio and Sebastian. The physical and auditory elements provided a fun bridge to analysing the professional RSC stage production in the next lesson.

References

- Department of Basic Education. (2011). *Curriculum and Assessment Policy Statement (CAPS): English Home Language Grades 10–12*. Government Printing Works.
- Shakespeare, W. (2008). *The Tempest* (S. Orgel, Ed.). Oxford University Press. (Original work published 1611)